# Shifted person indexicals under the complementizer *čto* in Russian: competence or performance?[*]

*Mikhail Knyazev*
Institute for Linguistic Studies RAS / HSE Universtity — St Petersburg
misha.knjazev@gmail.com

**Introduction.** In standard Russian, 1st and 2nd person pronouns in complement clauses of speech verbs must be interpreted relative to the current context. In colloquial speech, however, shifted interpretation is attested, as in corpus examples like (1).

(1) *On$_1$ prosto pozvonil I skazal, čto "**ja$_1$** v Krasnodare".*
Lit. 'He just called and said that I am in Krasnodar.' [Letuchiy 2023]

Letuchiy [2023] views such cases as quotation, made possible by the emerging use of *čto* as a quotative marker in colloquial registers. This suggests shifted person under *čto* is part of grammatical competence. Knyazev [to appear] provides further evidence from rating experiments that it is a competence phenomenon. In this paper, I reconsider these results and suggest that some of them may be more compatible with a performance explanation. The basic idea is that speakers provide intermediate ratings not because shifted readings are marginally acceptable, but because they can repair an unacceptable structure, as proposed for voice mismatches under VP ellipsis [Arregui et al. 2006] (but see [Merchant 2013]).

**Previous study.** Knyazev [to appear, Exp. 3] asked participants to rate sentences like (2a)–(3a) in contexts compatible only with a shifted reading of 1sg and 2sg pronouns; to further ensure shifted reading, the pronoun gender (on the agreeing predicate) mismatched that of the potential non-shifted referent. The sentences were compared with similar sentences like (2b)–(3b) that had no felicitous interpretation.

(2) Context: The supervisor$_{male}$ apologized to the PhD candidate$_{female}$ for choosing a topic badly. The PhD candidate$_{female}$ reports this to her male friend:
a. *Naučnyj rukovoditel' mne skazal čto **ja** neudačno **vybral** temu.*
Lit. 'The supervisor told me that **I**, **chose**$_{M.SG}$ a topic badly.' [SHIFTED]
b. *Naučnyj rukovoditel' mne skazal čto **ja** neudačno **vybrala** temu.*
Lit. 'The supervisor told me that **I chose**$_{F.SG}$ a topic badly.' [IMPOSSIBLE]

(3) Context: The boss$_{male}$ forbids Masha to leave work before 6 pm. Masha reports this to her male friend:
a. *Načal'nik mne skazal čto **ty dolžna** uxodit' ne ran'še 6.*
Lit. 'The boss told me that **you must**$_{F.SG}$ go no earlier than 6 pm.' [SHIFTED]
b. *Načal'nik mne skazal čto **ty dolžen** uxodit' ne ran'še 6.*
Lit. 'The boss told me that **you must**$_{M.SG}$ go no earlier than 6 pm.' [IMPOSSIBLE]

The results for 2nd person showed higher ratings for shifted (3.72) compared to impossible (2.04) condition.[1] First person showed only a numerical trend (2.67 vs. 2.19), which, though, was taken to reflect accidental features of the stimuli—especially given that in Exp. 2, with a similar manipulation, the corresponding contrast was present (3.24 vs. 2.10), cf. (4a)–(4b) below. Knyazev [to appear] concludes that shifted pronouns with *čto* are basically acceptable; otherwise comprehenders would be unable to interpret them, leading to no contrast with the impossible condition.

[*]The research was funded by the RSF (project No. 25-18-00938), https://rscf.ru/project/25-18-00938/.
[1]All the contrasts reported below were statistically significant ($p < 0.05$) in linear mixed-effects models predicting normalized (z-score) ratings from context type (impossible vs. shifted.mismatch); complement type (*čto* vs. *čto*-less) and their interaction.

The fact that such sentences were rated only as 3-4, below midpoint, is potentially problematic. Knyazev [to appear] offers two explanations. One is a general dispreference for shifted interpretations in non-narrative contexts [Köder et al. 2015]. The other is that gender mismatch may lead to a garden-path effect: comprehenders initially attempt a non-shifted interpretation and backtrack once they encounter the mismatch. Interestingly, Knyazev [to appear] discards this explanation since contexts without gender mismatch like (4c) were rated as *less* acceptable (2.61) than mismatch contexts like (4a), suggesting that the mismatch did not cause significant processing problems.

(4) Context: The supervisor$_{male}$ apologized to the PhD candidate$_{female}$ for choosing a topic badly. The PhD candidate$_{female}$ reports this to her male friend:

a. *Naučnyj rukovoditel' mne skazal čto* ***ja*** *neudačno* ***vybral*** *temu.*
Lit. 'The supervisor told me that **I**. **chose**$_{M.SG}$ a topic badly.'
[SHIFTED; MISMATCH]

b. *Naučnyj rukovoditel' mne skazal čto* ***ty*** *neudačno* ***vybrala*** *temu.*
Lit. 'The supervisor told me that **you chose**$_{F.SG}$ a topic badly.'
[IMPOSSIBLE]

c. Context: The supervisor$_{male}$ apologized to the PhD candidate$_{male}$ for choosing a topic badly. The PhD candidate$_{male}$ reports this to his female friend:
Lit. 'The supervisor told me that **I**. **chose**$_{M.SG}$ a topic badly.'
[SHIFTED; NO MISMATCH]

Crucially, the higher acceptability for the mismatch condition may arise in two ways. On the competence view, mismatch reinforces the context, helping comprehenders override the preference for non-shifted readings. On the repair view, shifted readings are unacceptable. In contexts without mismatch like (4c), comprehenders assign a non-shifted reading, contradicting the context and leading to full unacceptability. In mismatch contexts, comprehenders are precluded from doing so, forcing the parser to repair the structure, e.g., by ignoring the complementizer or inserting a null context-shifting operator. Repair may decrease acceptability while still resulting in higher ratings thanks to comprehensibility.

These views are hard to disentangle based on rating data, but reading times may help. The competence view predicts no significant delay at the mismatch point (the agreeing verb), because context already biases towards the shifted interpretation. The repair view predicts a strong disruption and significant delay, reflecting reanalysis.

**A pilot study.** To test these explanations, a self-paced reading pilot study was conducted on PCIbex Farm, with 48 participants recruited via Yandex.Tasks. The 2x2x2 design (with *čto*-less clauses included as baselines), materials (N=8 per person), and rating task replicated Knyazev [to appear, Exp. 3], cf. (2)–(3). Instead of auditory presentation, stimuli were presented one word at a time using PCIbex Farm's DashedSentence functionality. The shifted condition involved gender mismatch, while the impossible condition matched the gender of the non-shifted referent but mismatched the context.

The shifted conditions with *čto* were rated higher than impossible ones, with a stronger effect for 2nd person (1st: 2.91 vs. 2.51; 2nd: 3.80 vs. 1.70), replicating Exp. 3. With *čto*-less clauses, shifted readings were rated proportionally higher (1st: 3.38; 2nd: 4.68), also replicating Exp. 3.

Reading times exceeding 2 standard deviations from the participant mean were trimmed. At the agreeing predicate, the shifted condition showed a clear delay for 1st person (847 vs. 650 ms) but not for 2nd person, where there was an opposite effect (547 vs. 653 ms).

**The person asymmetry puzzle.** These results reveal a surprising dissociation between persons. The fact that with 1st person a gender mismatch causes a stronger delay than a contextual mismatch shows a clear bias for a non-shifted interpretation with 1st person. This is consistent

with the low acceptability of shifted 1st person with *čto* and points to a repair mechanism for cases where comprehenders do find such examples moderately acceptable (cf. (1)). By contrast, a stronger delay with the contextual compared to the gender mismatch with 2nd person suggests a much weaker bias for a non-shifted interpretation, consistent with the competence view: context alone can override the default, leading comprehenders not to consider the non-shifted referent at all, at least in constructions like (3). The difference in acceptability between shifted 1st and 2nd persons with *čto*, and the corresponding difference in reading times at the mismatch, present a puzzle that requires further investigation.

**References**


Arregui et al. 2006 — Arregui A., Clifton C., Frazier L., Moulton K. Processing elided verb phrases with flawed antecedents: the recycling hypothesis // *Journal of Memory and Language*. 2006. Vol. 55. No. 2. Pp. 232–246.

Knyazev to appear — Knyazev M. Direct deixis with 1st and 2nd person pronouns in Russian *čto*-clauses: acceptability judgment experiments. To appear in *Voprosy Jazykoznanija.*

Köder et al. 2015 — Köder F., Maier E., Hendriks P. Perspective shift increases processing effort of pronouns: a comparison between direct and indirect speech // *Language, Cognition and Neuroscience*. 2015. Vol. 30. No. 8. Pp. 940–946.

Letuchiy 2023 — Letuchiy A. Russian colloquial complement clauses with *čto*: Quotative use and other special properties // *Voprosy Jazykoznanija.* 2023. No. 3. Pp. 27–59.

Merchant 2013 — Merchant, J. Voice and ellipsis // *Linguistic Inquiry.* 2013, Vol. 44. No. 1. Pp. 77–108.